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MIKE DITKA 1939-2026

Made of Iron

As tributes pour in, legacy of 'Da Coach' evokes soul of city

By Rebecca Johnson, Allison Kiehl, Lila Hempel-Edgers and Shun Graves
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Three images of Mike Ditka filled the large screen outside the south entrance of Soldier Field Friday afternoon alongside simple text, "1939-2026."

Michael Barone, 48, of New Jersey, stopped to take a picture. "He was an icon. It's tragic when you lose someone like that," Barone said. "He embodies Chicago. He was that personality, that attitude." The Super Bowl-winning



coach and Chicago Bears Hall of Famer died at age 86, his family announced Friday. A cause of death wasn't given. Tributes from across the Chicago area and country immediately began pouring in, from across all walks of life. Ditka was perhaps best

known for coaching the 1985 Bears to the franchise's sole Super Bowl championship. He also played for six seasons in Chicago and was the first tight end inducted into the Pro Football Hall of Fame.

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Bears' iconic Hall of Fame tight end, Super Bowl-winning coach dies at 86

By Don Pierson
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Nobody embodied Chicago Bears football more than Mike Ditka, who became the face of the franchise as both a Pro Football Hall of Fame tight end and a Super Bowl-winning coach.

It was a face that even resembled the bear on the team logo, a face once described as "a clenched fist" that became familiar to millions — first as a player starting in 1961, then as Bears coach from 1982-92 and finally as a ubiquitous celebrity promoter and television commentator.

Ditka, who coached the 1985 Bears to the franchise's only Super Bowl championship, has died at age 86, according to his family, who released a statement Friday.

The Bears, in a statement, said, "Mike's impact on the Chicago Bears organization, over decades as a player, coach, and proud icon and ambassador for

See **DITKA** on Page A4

Top: A photograph made with Polaroid film of Mike Ditka in 2005, who coached the Bears to a title 20 years prior. **CHARLES CHERNEY/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**
Above: Manager Mike Stamp covers a finger gesture on a cutout of Ditka inside Gracie O'Malley's in Chicago on Friday. **JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

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